Sybil Birling

Sybil Birling is cold -hearted and sophisticated and regarded as her husband's social superior. She is described at the start as **"about fifty, a rather cold woman and her husband's social superior."** She is a 'snob', very aware of the differences between social classes and therefore very arrogant. She is dismissive of the poorer classes and has no respect for them or the inspector. She is a liar, very controlling and is patronising to her own children. She sees Sheila and Eric still as **"children"** and speaks patronisingly to them. She uses her power to judge people , especially the working classes and says that Eva 'was giving herself ridiculous airs." when Eva does not take the money.

Believes she is always right and therefore ignorant – She is set in her own ways and class and doesn't believe a girl can have "fine feelings" Apathetic and uncaring, she dismisses Eva/Daisy as just '**girls of that class.**" Her charity work is conducted for selfish reasons. Mrs Birling's attitude is unchanged by the events of the play

She **tries to deny things** that she doesn't want to believe like Eric's drinking, Gerald's affair with Eva, and the fact that a working -class girl would refuse money even if it was stolen, claiming **"She was giving herself ridiculous airs."** She admits she was **"prejudiced"** against the girl who applied to her committee for help and saw it as her **"duty"** to refuse to help her. Her narrow sense of morality dictates that the father of a child should be responsible for its welfare, regardless of circumstances.

At the end of the play, she has had to come to terms with the fact that her son is a heavy drinker who got a girl pregnant and stole money to support her, her daughter will not marry a good social **'catch'** and that her own reputation within the town will be sullied. Yet, like her husband, she refuses to believe that she did anything wrong and doesn't accept responsibility for her part in Eva's death.

How does Priestley portray some of the main ideas and themes through Mrs Birling in the play?